



change, but the game must go on,” said Kalyan Chaubey, the AIFF President.

Since replacing the Federation Cup in 2018, the Super Cup has been central to Odisha’s long-standing ambitions of becoming India’s sporting capital — with all but one edition staged in Bhubaneswar.

Yet with every passing year, the gloss has worn thin, and the voices of coaches and players have echoed off concrete instead of being met with cheering stands. The AIFF has now decided to make it the curtain-raiser rather than the dying act this season, pitching its tent in Goa.

Choppy waters

The year 2025, up to October, has seen the AIFF and Football Sports Development Limited (FSDL) — the body that ran the ISL until the 2024–25 season — locked in a tug of war, with their relationship set to

Title tide: Defending champion FC Goa will look for an early Christmas on home soil, with coach Manolo Marquez rejoining the side after a nightmarish stint as India coach. FC GOA MEDIA

end in two months. A full season without top-flight football, India’s poor international performances, and Mohun Bagan Super Giant’s consecutive withdrawals from the AFC Champions League Two (ACL 2) threaten to dent India’s AFC coefficient ranking.

In the past, the same metric saw India’s slots reduced to zero in the AFC Champions League Elite — and history, if not careful, may yet rhyme.

In such times, the Super Cup provides a last-ditch opportunity to salvage continental berths for Indian clubs. The winner of the Super Cup will secure a place in the preliminary stage of ACL 2.

Yet familiar cracks remain — the tournament’s format has changed more frequently than a losing team’s tactics.

The 2025–26 Super Cup will feature 16 teams divided into four groups of four, with the group winners qualifying for the semifinals.

Battle royale: Mohun Bagan and East Bengal are set to face off in the group stage, setting up a fourth Kolkata derby this season. East Bengal has won the first two, while Bagan claimed the latest to lift the IFA Shield on October 18.

FSDL/ISL MEDIA



Super Cup format over the years



2018-2019: Qualification round + single-elimination knockouts

2023-2024: Group stage + knockouts

2024-2025: Single-leg knockouts.

2025-2026: Group stage + knockouts

The tournament’s broadcast tells the tale of two cities: all matches in Fatorda will be televised or streamed, while those in Bambolim will unfold off-camera (at the time of writing).

That four of the 16 teams — FC Goa, Bengaluru FC, Mohun Bagan Super Giant and Mumbai City FC — have been spared travel and guaranteed broadcast coverage for all their group-stage matches also raises the age-old question: are all clubs truly equal before the federation?

Reshuffle of the roster

The uncertainty surrounding the ISL has affected transfers,